

Practice Paper 1: Answers and Marking Guide

Admiration and irony; memory and loneliness · Three hours · 100 marks

PAPER I · 40 MARKS

Answer **all** the questions in Section A. Select **either** I, II **or** III from Section B and answer all the questions given below it.

Paper I · Section A: Poetry, Prose and Drama 30 marks

Read the following extracts and answer all the questions given below them.

I POETRY

I (i) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"He clasps the crag with crooked hands;
Close to the sun in lonely lands,
Ring'd with the azure world, he stands."

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|--|---------|
| (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. | 1 mark |
| (b) Who is referred to as 'he'? | 1 mark |
| (c) What are the 'crooked hands'? | 1 mark |
| (d) What impression of the eagle do these lines create? Refer to one poetic technique. | 2 marks |

(a) "The Eagle" by Alfred, Lord Tennyson.

(b) The eagle.

(c) The eagle's curved, hooked talons (claws), which grip the rock.

(d) The eagle seems majestic, powerful and alone, like a king surveying his kingdom.

Personification ("he", "hands") gives the bird human dignity; the hard alliteration of "clasps", "crag", "crooked" suggests strength; "Close to the sun" is a hyperbole showing the great height of his perch. (Any one technique, well explained.)

I (ii) · PRACTICE QUESTION

"So I have learned many things, son.
I have learned to wear many faces
like dresses – homeface,
officeface, streetface, hostface,"

- (a) Name the poem from which these lines are taken. Name the poet. 1 mark
- (b) Who is the speaker? 1 mark
- (c) Name the poetic technique in 'like dresses'. 1 mark
- (d) What does the speaker mean by 'wear many faces'? What is his attitude towards this? 2 marks
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- (a) "Once Upon a Time" by Gabriel Okara.
- (b) A father (the poet himself), speaking to his young son.
- (c) Simile: the faces are compared to dresses that are changed for each occasion.
- (d) He has learnt to put on a false expression to suit each situation (at home, in the office, in the street, as a host), hiding his real feelings. He is not proud of it: he regrets this hypocrisy and later says he wants to unlearn it.

II PROSE

II (i) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"It was probably the first time for twenty years that anyone had smiled in that lumber-room."

- (a) Name the text from which this line is taken. Name the author. 1 mark
- (b) Who smiled in the lumber-room? 1 mark
- (c) Why did he smile at this moment? 1 mark
- (d) What does this sentence suggest about the lumber-room and about the aunt? 2 marks
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- (a) "The Lumber Room" by Saki (H. H. Munro).
- (b) Nicholas.
- (c) He heard his aunt shouting that she could see him in the gooseberry garden, when in fact he was safely inside the lumber-room. She was searching in the wrong place.
- (d) The room has been kept locked, unused and joyless for years, so its treasures give no pleasure to anyone. The aunt is a joyless, unimaginative person who preserves beautiful things instead of enjoying them. The sentence is also ironic: the child has outwitted her.

II (ii) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"Not thirty seconds had passed when we heard what sounded like fire crackers going off. Suddenly a shout came from the front: 'Get down they are shooting at the bus.'"

- (a) Name the text from which these lines are taken. Name the speaker/author. 1 mark
- (b) Where were the speaker and his companions at this moment? 1 mark
- (c) What did the 'fire crackers' turn out to be? 1 mark
- (d) Comment on the effect of comparing the sound to 'fire crackers'. 2 marks

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- (a) "The Lahore Attack" by Kumar Sangakkara.
 - (b) In the Sri Lankan team bus, on the way to the stadium in Lahore, Pakistan, for a day of the Test match.
 - (c) Gunfire: terrorists were attacking the team bus.
 - (d) It is ironic: fire crackers are harmless and festive, but the sound was deadly gunfire. It shows how unexpected the attack was and how the players at first did not realise the danger, so the sudden shout comes as a shock and builds tension.

III DRAMA

III (i) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"I wished I might have lived with you forever, setting up our world in the middle of this field, playing with children and working on the farm."

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
- (b) Who speaks these words, and to whom? 1 mark
- (c) At what point in the play are these words spoken? 1 mark
- (d) What do these words reveal about the speaker? 2 marks

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- (a) "Twilight of a Crane" by Junji Kinoshita.
 - (b) Tsu, to her husband Yohyo.
 - (c) Near the end, when Tsu has woven the last cloth and her true form as a crane has been seen, so she must leave Yohyo for ever.
 - (d) Her deep, unselfish love for Yohyo and her longing for a simple, peaceful family life close to nature. They also show her sorrow: the dream has been destroyed by greed for money, so the lines are full of regret and sacrifice.

III (ii) • PRACTICE QUESTION

"That's real silly feminine logic. That's why I never did like, and don't like now, to have to talk to women. I'd rather sit on a barrel of gunpowder than talk to a woman."

- (a) Name the play from which these lines are taken. Name the playwright. 1 mark
 - (b) Who is the speaker? 1 mark
 - (c) What has made the speaker so angry? 1 mark
 - (d) Comment on the exaggeration in the last sentence. Why is it ironic later in the play? 2 marks
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- (a) "The Bear" by Anton Chekhov.
- (b) Smirnov.
- (c) Popova has refused to pay her late husband's debt of 1,200 roubles today, saying she is in no 'state of mind' to deal with money and that her steward will pay the day after tomorrow.
- (d) The hyperbole (sitting on gunpowder is safer than talking to a woman) shows his fury and contempt for women, and creates humour. It is ironic because within minutes he falls in love with Popova and asks her to marry him.

Paper I • Section B: Novels 10 marks

Select **EITHER** I, II **OR** III and answer all the questions given below it.

I • THE PRINCE AND THE PAUPER

Read the following extract from *The Prince and the Pauper* by Mark Twain and answer all the questions given below it.

"The mock King's cheeks were flushed with excitement, his eyes were flashing, his senses swam in a delirium of pleasure. At this point, just as he was raising his hand to fling another rich largess, he caught sight of a pale, astounded face, which was strained forward out of the second rank of the crowd, its intense eyes riveted upon him. A sickening consternation struck through him; he recognised his mother! and up flew his hand, palm outward, before his eyes—that old involuntary gesture, born of a forgotten episode, and perpetuated by habit. In an instant more she had torn her way out of the press, and past the guards, and was at his side. She embraced his leg, she covered it with kisses, she cried, "O my child, my darling!" lifting toward him a face that was transfigured with joy and love. The same instant an officer of the King's Guard snatched her away with a curse, and sent her reeling back whence she came with a vigorous impulse from his strong arm. The words "I do not know you, woman!" were falling from Tom Canty's lips when this piteous thing occurred; but it smote him to the heart to see her treated so."

- (i) When and where does this incident take place? 2 marks
- (ii) Why did Tom say "I do not know you, woman!"? 2 marks
- (iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) a sickening consternation 1 mark

(b) transfigured with joy and love

1 mark

(iv) How does this incident affect Tom? To what theme of the novel does it relate?

4 marks

(i) When and where does this incident take place?

During the Recognition Procession through the streets of London, on the day before the coronation, when Tom Canty, now treated as the King, rides in the royal procession.

(ii) Why did Tom say "I do not know you, woman!"?

He was caught up in the pleasure and pride of royal splendour, and he was afraid that his real identity as a pauper would be exposed. The words came out in shock, almost without thinking.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) a sickening consternation

A sudden feeling of shock and fear so strong that it made him feel ill.

(b) transfigured with joy and love

Her face was completely changed, lit up with happiness and love.

(iv) How does this incident affect Tom? To what theme of the novel does it relate?

Shame "consumed his pride to ashes": royalty loses its sweetness, he rides on with bowed head, hears nothing of the cheering, and wishes he were free of his "captivity". The incident shows Tom's basic goodness, because he feels deep remorse. Themes: true human values (love, family, honesty) are worth more than wealth and power; the corrupting effect of power; identity and appearance. (Award 4 marks if at least one point is well explained with a theme.)

II · BRINGING TONY HOME

As a boy, the narrator often wanders with his friends near the R.A.F. camp. One evening he watches a truck bring a white officer to his billet, and soon the notes of a piano come floating out. The narrator says:

"the music was vaguely familiar and the smell of roast beef was still in the air coming from Kitchen No.1 and I thought of the lonely nights I spent at 'Greenlands' in Havelock Town"

(i) When and where does this scene take place?

2 marks

(ii) Which two things bring back the narrator's memories of 'Greenlands'?

2 marks

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) vaguely familiar

1 mark

(b) still in the air

1 mark

(iv) What does this memory reveal about the narrator's feelings? To what theme of the novel does it relate?

4 marks

(i) When and where does this scene take place?

In the narrator's boyhood, when he roams with his friends (Sirisena's gang) outside the R.A.F. camp, near the officers' billets.

(ii) Which two things bring back the narrator's memories of 'Greenlands'?

The sound of the piano music and the smell of roast beef.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) vaguely familiar

He felt he had heard it before but could not remember it clearly.

(b) still in the air

The smell remained, lingering strongly for a long time.

(iv) What does this memory reveal about the narrator's feelings? To what theme of the novel does it relate?

He remembers being lonely and homesick at "Greenlands": although it was a grand house, he missed his mother's warmth. A sound and a smell are enough to bring the past back, which shows how deeply childhood experiences stay with us. Themes: memory and nostalgia; the importance of a mother's love; social change and the loss of the family's former way of life.

III • THE VENDOR OF SWEETS

Mali has gone to America to learn to be a writer, and his letters begin to arrive in Malgudi. Narayan writes:

"Jagan stuffed his jibba pocket with the letters and pulled them out for choice reading of passages to all and sundry, mostly to his cousin, who, as ever, remained an uncomplaining listener. Gradually his reading of the Bhagavad Gita was replaced by the blue airmail letters."

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|---|---------|
| (i) When does this take place, and to whom does Jagan read the letters most? | 2 marks |
| (ii) Why does Jagan carry the letters in his pocket? | 2 marks |
| (iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) all and sundry | 1 mark |
| (b) an uncomplaining listener | 1 mark |
| (iv) What is ironic about the last sentence? What does it reveal about Jagan? | 4 marks |

(i) When does this take place, and to whom does Jagan read the letters most?

After Mali has left for America to study writing; Jagan reads them mostly to his cousin, in Malgudi.

(ii) Why does Jagan carry the letters in his pocket?

He is proud of his son and loves him dearly, so he wants to keep the letters with him and show them off by reading them to everyone.

(iii) Explain the meaning of the following phrase as it occurs in the passage: (a) all and sundry

Everyone, without making any distinction.

(b) an uncomplaining listener

Someone who listens patiently without objecting or getting bored.

(iv) What is ironic about the last sentence? What does it reveal about Jagan?

Jagan claims to live by the Gita and Gandhi's teaching, yet letters praising American life (which he dislikes) take the place of his holy book. It reveals his blind love and attachment to his son, his pride and boastfulness, and the contradiction between his spiritual ideals and his worldly feelings. It also foreshadows the father-son conflict and the clash between tradition and modernity.

Paper II • Essays 60 marks

PAPER II • 60 MARKS

Answer **four** questions, selecting **one** each from the four sections: Poetry, Drama, Prose and Fiction.

HOW PAPER II ESSAYS ARE MARKED (15 MARKS EACH)

Content 7 • Organisation 4 • Language 4. Examiners reward relevant points from the text, apt quotations, a clear argument that answers the question, and your own sensible response. The points below are a guide, not a fixed list.

POETRY (Answer one question only)

1. In 'To the Nile', Keats moves from wonder at the river's legend to a more realistic view of it.

Discuss with reference to the poem.

15 marks

- Introduction: a Petrarchan sonnet in which the poet addresses the Nile directly; the octave and the sestet show two attitudes.
- Octave (lines 1-8): wonder and reverence. The Nile is personified as "Son of the old moon-mountains African" and "Chief of the Pyramid and Crocodile"; it is the "Nurse of swart nations since the world began".
- Doubt and mystery: rhetorical questions ("Art thou so fruitful?") ask whether the river only charms ("beguile") weary men into honouring it.
- The volta at line 9: "O may dark fancies err! they surely do". The poet rejects his gloomy imagination.

- Sestet: a realistic, gentle picture. "'Tis ignorance that makes a barren waste / Of all beyond itself": the Nile has "Green rushes like our rivers", enjoys "The pleasant sunrise" and "to the sea as happily dost haste".
- Effect: the exotic river becomes as familiar as an English river; the poem suggests that ignorance creates false ideas about distant lands.
- Conclusion: the change from reverence to realism is supported by personification, apostrophe, rhetorical questions and the sonnet structure.

2. "'War is Kind' uses bitter irony to attack those who glorify war." Examine how Stephen Crane achieves this.

15 marks

- Introduction: the title and the refrain "War is kind" say the opposite of what the poet means (verbal irony / sarcasm).
- The mourners: the maiden, the babe and the mother are told "Do not weep", while the images show violent death: the lover "threw wild hands toward the sky", the father "tumbled in the yellow trenches".
- The soldiers: "Little souls who thirst for fight, / These men were born to drill and die": a sympathetic, belittling view; alliteration of "drill and die".
- The glory of war is empty: "The unexplained glory flies above them"; the "battle-god" and his "kingdom" are "A field where a thousand corpses lie".
- Military display: drums, "Swift, blazing flag", "Eagle with crest of red and gold" contrast with death; ironic commands "Point for them the virtue of slaughter".
- Structure: alternating stanzas (mourners/soldiers) and the repeated refrain build the irony; the mother's heart "hung humble as a button / On the bright splendid shroud of your son".
- Conclusion: through irony, contrast and harsh imagery Crane exposes war as cruel and wasteful.

3. Okara's 'Once Upon a Time' contrasts the sincerity of the past with the falseness of the present. How does the poet present this contrast?

15 marks

- Introduction: a father speaks to his son; the title suggests a fairy tale, a past that seems lost.
- Past: "they used to laugh with their hearts / and laugh with their eyes"; "shake hands with their hearts".

- Present: "now they only laugh with their teeth, / while their ice-block-cold eyes / search behind my shadow"; handshakes "without hearts" while "their left hands search / my empty pockets".
- False politeness: "'Feel at home!' 'Come again'" until "I find doors shut on me".
- The speaker's own guilt: "I have learned to wear many faces / like dresses"; saying "Goodbye" for "Good-riddance".
- Hope: he wants to "unlearn all these muting things" and asks his son to "show me how / I used to laugh"; the child represents innocence.
- Techniques: contrast, repetition, simile, metaphor ("ice-block-cold eyes"), compound words ("homeface, officeface"), the simile of the "snake's bare fangs".
- Conclusion: the poem criticises a modern, materialistic society and values the sincerity of childhood.

4. "'Father and Son' presents two points of view, and the listener can understand both." Do you agree? Discuss with reference to the poem. 15 marks

- Introduction: a song-poem by Cat Stevens written as a dialogue between a father and his son; the two voices alternate.
- The father's view: he has lived longer, wants his son to settle down, be patient and not make hasty decisions; his advice comes from love and experience.
- The son's view: he feels unheard and frustrated; he has always been told to listen rather than speak, and now he must go and find his own way.
- Why both are understandable: the father fears for his son; the son needs independence and identity. Neither is a villain.
- The generation gap: a universal conflict between experience and youth, stability and change.
- Techniques: dramatic dialogue, contrast of calm and urgent tones, repetition, the son's decision to leave.
- Personal response: agree or disagree, but support it with clear references to what each speaker says (paraphrase is acceptable).

5. How does Raymond Wilson create both suspense and humour in 'Two's Company'? 15 marks

- Introduction: a narrative poem about a sceptic who spends a night in a "haunted" house to prove ghosts do not exist.

- Humour from his confidence: he dismisses "tittle-tattle / as ghosts that groan and chains that rattle".
- Setting builds suspense: "dusk was falling / with a hunchback moon and screech owls calling".
- Growing fear: noises outside, "chains rattled, someone screamed!"; he draws the curtain, locks the door, picks up the poker, checks the doors, hides in the cupboard.
- Comic irony: the brackets reveal what he really does: "(but just the same, he draws the curtain)", "(of course he knows that no-one's there, / but no harm's done by taking care!)".
- The twist ending: in the cupboard "a voice breathes softly, 'How do you do! / I am the ghost. Pray who are you?'"; the title "Two's Company" becomes a joke.
- Techniques: rhyming couplets, lively rhythm, onomatopoeia, dramatic irony.
- Conclusion: suspense and humour work together to mock false bravery.

DRAMA (Answer one question only)

6. "Tsu is destroyed not by her husband's cruelty but by the greed of others." Discuss with reference to 'Twilight of a Crane'.

15 marks

- Introduction: a modern Japanese play based on the folk tale of the crane wife; Tsu is a crane who becomes Yohyo's wife out of gratitude and love.
- Yohyo is not cruel: he is simple, kind and childlike, and at first he lives happily with Tsu.
- Sodo and Unzu: greedy villagers who see the value of the senba-ori cloth and tempt Yohyo with money and the excitement of the capital.
- Their influence changes Yohyo: he begins to want money, so he presses Tsu to weave again, although each cloth costs her feathers and strength.
- Yet Yohyo shares the blame: he breaks his promise and looks at her while she weaves.
- Tsu's sacrifice: she weaves the last cloth with her whole heart, leaves two pieces and flies away.
- Conclusion: the greed of others is the main cause, but Yohyo's weakness allows it; the play shows how greed destroys innocence and love.

7. How does Chekhov use exaggeration and sudden changes of mood to entertain the audience in 'The Bear'?

15 marks

- Introduction: a one-act farce about a widow, Popova, and a landowner, Smirnov, who comes to collect a debt.

- Exaggerated mourning: Popova has "buried myself between four walls" and vows to wear black for ever, yet Smirnov mocks her: "you haven't forgotten to powder your face!"
- Exaggerated anger: Smirnov shouts, insults women, says "I'd rather sit on a barrel of gunpowder than talk to a woman", and breaks the furniture.
- The quarrel becomes a duel: "Here the sexes are equal! I'll shoot her on principle!"
- The sudden reversal: while teaching her to fire, he falls in love: "Her eyes, her eyes! What an inspiring woman!"; "I'm weak, I'm wax, I've melted".
- Luka adds comedy: his panic and "Little fathers!... What people!"; the servants arrive with weapons to find the pair kissing.
- Conclusion: exaggeration, quick dialogue and reversals make the audience laugh while mocking false sentiment and pride.

PROSE (Answer one question only)

8. "The extract from 'Wave' shows how quickly ordinary life can turn into tragedy." Discuss.

15 marks

- Introduction: a memoir of the 2004 tsunami at Yala; the author lost her husband, sons and parents.
- Ordinary beginning: a family holiday, playful children, a normal morning.
- The first sign looks harmless: Orlantha says "Oh my God, the sea's coming in."; Sonali sees only a "white curl of a big wave".
- Rapid change: the water keeps coming; the family runs; they escape in a jeep.
- Terror and helplessness: "The jeep rocked. It was floating, the wheels no longer gripping the ground."
- Techniques: first-person narration, short sentences, present details and silence ("No one spoke. No one uttered a sound.") that show shock.
- Conclusion: within minutes a peaceful holiday becomes a catastrophe; the extract reminds us how fragile life is.

9. Discuss how Saki uses humour and irony to criticise the aunt in 'The Lumber Room'. 15 marks

- Introduction: a short story about a clever boy, Nicholas, and his strict, self-righteous aunt.
- Ironical narrator: the aunt is "the soi-disant aunt" and "the aunt-by-assertion"; "older, wiser, and better people" are proved wrong about the frog.
- Her punishments: she invents treats such as the Jagborough trip to punish the children; "a woman of few ideas, with immense powers of concentration".

- Her blindness: she does not listen ("He told you twice"); she guards the gooseberry garden while Nicholas enters the lumber-room.
- She hides beauty: she thinks "things spoil by use"; "the first time for twenty years that anyone had smiled in that lumber-room".
- Reversal: she falls into the rain-water tank and Nicholas pretends she is "the Evil One"; the strawberry jam exposes her lie.
- Ending: the trip is a failure; tea is eaten in "a fearsome silence".
- Conclusion: humour and irony criticise strict, unimaginative adults and celebrate a child's imagination.

10. What qualities of a good leader does Kumar Sangakkara reveal in 'The Lahore Attack'?

15 marks

- Introduction: Sangakkara describes the 2009 terrorist attack on the Sri Lankan team bus in Lahore.
- Calmness: "There was no insane panic. There was absolute clarity and awareness of what was happening at that moment."
- Honesty: he admits what he cannot fully understand: "I had great sympathy and compassion for them, but had no real experience with which I could draw parallels."
- Humility: "His sincerity was overwhelming. I felt humbled."
- Team spirit: after the attack they "sit in the dressing room and talk"; "there is laughter and the jokes have started to flow".
- Courage and pride: "we were not cowed. We were not down and out."
- Sense of responsibility: "Our emotions held true to our role as unofficial ambassadors."
- Conclusion: courage, calm, humility and loyalty to the team and country are qualities of a true leader.

11. Contrast the Nightingale's idea of love with the Student's idea of love in 'The Nightingale and the Rose'.

15 marks

- Introduction: a fairy tale by Oscar Wilde in which a bird sacrifices her life for a student's love.
- The Nightingale: love is precious and cannot be bought: "Pearls and pomegranates cannot buy it, nor is it set forth in the marketplace."
- She gives her life: "Yet Love is better than Life"; she sings all night with her breast against the thorn.

- The Student: his love depends on a red rose and a dance; he weeps for it but does not understand the Nightingale.
- He judges by reason and books: "she is all style, without any sincerity"; he thinks art is selfish.
- His final view: "What a silly thing Love is... It is not half as useful as Logic"; he throws the rose away and returns to his books.
- Conclusion: the contrast exposes shallow, practical love and praises selfless, sacrificial love.

FICTION (Answer one question only)

12. "Tom Canty's experience as king shows that goodness matters more than noble birth."

Discuss with reference to 'The Prince and the Pauper'.

15 marks

- Introduction: Tom, a pauper from Offal Court, and Prince Edward exchange places by chance.
- Tom's good heart: he judges with mercy, for example pardoning the woman and her daughter accused of witchcraft because "other mothers are made in like mould".
- He shows common sense and kindness, though he lacks training; he is wiser than the cruel laws.
- Weakness: power and splendour tempt him; he denies his mother, but his remorse shows his conscience.
- Edward learns among the poor: cruelty, hunger and unjust laws teach him mercy.
- Ending: Edward rules with mercy and rewards Tom; character is shaped by experience, not birth.
- Conclusion: agree, with examples; Twain criticises a society that values birth and clothes more than goodness.

13. Discuss the role of memory in 'Bringing Tony Home'.

15 marks

- Introduction: an adult narrator, a film-maker, looks back on his boyhood and his dog Tony.
- Memory as structure: the three-part, fragmented story moves between periods of his life.
- Senses trigger memory: sounds and smells (a piano, roast beef; a train like the cry of a chained dog) bring back the past.
- Painful memories: leaving Depanama, the parting with Tony, Tony running away while he is ill.

- Happy memories: Tony's "sharp clipped aristocratic bark", the joyful reunion, the long walk home.
- Memory of a vanished Sri Lanka: ration books, slow buses, trees, waterways and friendly people.
- Conclusion: the past is "embedded deep in our psyche"; memory gives the novel its emotional power.

14. "Jagan is a man of contradictions." Discuss with reference to 'The Vendor of Sweets'. 15 marks

- Introduction: Jagan, a sweet-vendor in Malgudi, follows Gandhi and the Bhagavad Gita.
- Simplicity: he spins his own cloth, cooks simply, wears sandals from the leather of animals that died naturally.
- Love of money: he keeps a secret account of untaxed "free cash" and enjoys counting it.
- He preaches self-control ("Conquer taste") yet sells sweets for profit.
- As a father: he spoils Mali and boasts about his letters, yet later struggles against him.
- Gandhian methods used in a family quarrel: non-violent non-cooperation, cutting the price of sweets.
- Ending: he retires to a garden across the river, yet takes his cheque book.
- Conclusion: Narayan presents him with sympathy and humour as a mixture of strength and weakness.

These are original LitHelp practice questions written to the format of the G.C.E. (O/L) 2023(2024) and 2024(2025) papers and the Ministry of Education's 2025(2026) model papers. They are not official past-paper questions. For copyrighted set texts, only short lines are quoted and the situation is described in our own words.